

Part Four

PROGRAM IMPLEMENTATION

UNTRAINED BEGINNER: ROUTINE CONSTRUCTION AND PROGRESSION

INTRODUCTION

The programs included in this book are examples to give you an *idea* of what your created routine could look like. Don't use these routines verbatim; instead follow them as guidelines and modify them to fit your own goals, recovery factors, and to allow room for other activities you enjoy. The goal of *Overcoming Gravity* is to teach you how to construct effective routines to progress you toward your personal goals. If you use the examples offered verbatim, you are missing the point—you must learn to schedule your own routines to fit your own life. Never take advice blindly—there may be something that works better for you!

It is common for some athletes to come in with a flexibility or skill deficit despite having the strength to execute some high-level strength movements (especially in the context of handstands). Athletes with a weight-lifting background and those who participate in sports at a competitive level will find this to be the case. Not everyone has developed their strength and flexibility to be uniform across the board on the provided strength and progression charts. This is normal.

The area(s) where you are lacking could be the place where you make the most progress, provided that comparable amounts of time are invested on all aspects of development. Working your strengths is good, but it is also important to bring up weaknesses, work on flexibility, and ensure your skills are uniform between push and pull exercises. This will help you remain injury-free. The ambition for developing higher-level straight-arm isometrics routed through the skill and strength-skill movements like handstands and straight-arm press handstands will pay dividends later in your training.

You may find that you progress with certain techniques or exercises much more quickly than with others, given your own abilities and anthropometry (limb lengths). You can approach this either by decreasing the overall volume of these exercises or playing to your strengths. Make sure that you keep yourself structurally balanced.

The material in this chapter will show you how to modify material that was presented earlier into a coherent routine that works for you. The focus will be on helping you select proper exercises, frequency, volume,

and repetition schemes for your own workouts. Think of the earlier chapters as puzzle pieces and these next four chapters as those pieces coming together to form a clear picture.

Regarding *notation*—example routines will be written in several different notations. You must develop the ability to read various routine notations, since different coaches and athletes use different types of notations. Sometimes the notation will read *exercise: sets x reps*; other times, *sets x reps of exercise*. There are many variations.

UNTRAINED BEGINNER: ROUTINE CONSTRUCTION

To review, here are general needs of the *rank* or *untrained beginner*:

- Become introduced to fundamental exercises and attain a good proficiency in them.
- In most cases, utilize a higher number of repetitions to solidify movement patterns and build up connective tissue strength.
- Focus heavily on any individual weaknesses that you bring to exercising. For example, if you have a desk job, you may have issues stemming from poor posture that could lead to injury if left unaddressed. Most sedentary individuals tend to have very poor mobility and flexibility.
- Get on a generalized, balanced routine that will begin with high repetitions and then transition to traditional strength training.

At the lowest levels of ability, your aim should be to develop basic strength, prepare the joints for upcoming levels of ability, and gain mobility, especially in the shoulder girdle, back, and hips. Most untrained beginners are new to the world of exercise or have not exercised in some time. Other populations that may fit into this category are athletes of advanced age, those who have previous injuries, or those with such busy schedules they cannot dedicate much time to exercise.

If you are new to organized exercise, you will need a plan that starts you off slowly so your body can prepare for the rigors of exercise. Here is a list of goals from the sample routine in Chapter 5. These are arbitrary goals, selected as hypothetical examples to show you how to progress using a routine. You will select your own list of goals.

Sample Goals

- 10 Freestanding Handstands
- 5 Strict Muscle-ups
- 5s Planche
- 5s Front Lever
- 10 Pistols
- 10 Vertical V-Sits
- 5s Iron Cross

These are target goals; a beginner must work their way up to them. At this stage, upper-level goals like back levers, front levers, planches, and other isometrics should not be part of your routine. You must first develop strength in the basics and perform high-repetition work coupled with mobility in order to prepare your joints and connective tissues adequately.

Practice the exercises and next progressions at this skill level on the strength and skill progression charts. In the range of Level 1-4, you will notice that there are only a few exercises that go down to Level 1-2. At these levels, you will focus primarily on fundamental upper-body exercises like wall handstands, lower-level L-sit progressions, pushups, pull-ups, dips, and rows. The rest of your routine will reflect this. (see *strength work*)

Warm-Up

- Blood Flow: 10-20 Burpees, 60s Crawling (or variable distance, such as 100 meters)
- Mobility: 15x Wrist Circles, Shoulder Circles, Bodyweight Squats, and any other body part or joint that needs to be warmed up, 60s of Support Hold Work (parallel bars or rings or chairs/counters), 5x Skin the Cat / German Hangs
- Positional Drills: 30-60s of Plank, Both Side Planks, Reverse Plank, Hollow, and Arch Holds.

Let's talk about the *blood flow* portion of the warm-up first. For untrained beginners, burpees with a pushup (start standing, squat down, pushup position, pushup, squat position, end with a jump) may actually take away from your workout if they are too intense. Squat thrusts might be a better option to increase your heart rate and kick-start blood flow. If you are very new to exercise or out of shape and have not yet reached Level 1, I recommend employing a different exercise, such as jumping rope, jumping jacks, or light jogging.

Mobility should be tailored for the individual based on their needs and goals. The mobility section of the sample routine currently lists wrist circles, shoulder circles, bodyweight squats, sixty seconds of support hold work, and five German hangs. This may not be enough mobility work for an individual who is untrained or out of shape. If you have any range of motion issues or previous injuries, you need to perform more mobility work for those areas. Wrist circles usually work great for warming up your wrists. However, individuals who regularly use computers and/or those with tight wrists from a previous injury might need an extensive wrist warm-up that could include:

- Stretching your wrists with palms flat and hands pointed in all directions. Perform each hand direction individually and move in and out of these positions 5-10 times.
- Stretching your wrists with the back of your palm against the ground and hands pointed in all directions. Perform each hand direction individually and move in and out of these positions 5-10 times.
- Placing your palms flat against the ground and pulsing your fingers into the ground to lift your palms off the ground.
- Placing the palm of one hand flat on the ground and use the other hand to pick up one finger at a time to mobilize each finger individually.

This is just mobility work for the wrist. There are plenty of other mobility exercises for the elbows, shoulders, scapular, back, and legs that can be used depending on which parts of your body feel tight. As a beginner, it can be very helpful to have a light mobility or stretching routine to perform on rest days. Mobility work can be time-consuming; if the amount of mobility work your joints need is too much to perform *with* a workout, put it all in a single routine for your rest day. This will enable you to work less mobility on your workout days so that you have more time with skill building.

Keep in mind that mobility work will be beneficial in the long run. Lower-level flexibility and joint work will get your joints used to moving to end range of motion without a lot of weight on them and this will

prepare them to handle heavier loads down the road. This will be essential when you progress with your exercises. (such as when moving from standard handstands to one-arm handstands).

Positional drills will also be quite useful in the long run, as they will help you maintain correct body positioning while performing more difficult exercises. You should perform positional drills now, at this low skill level, so you have time to get used to maintaining body tension when connecting the exercises, critical for performing more advanced bodyweight exercises correctly. You can phase out positional drills as you become stronger and more versed in correct technique, but they are vital in the beginning. The plank, side planks, reverse (stomach up) plank, and hollow/arch holds are good for learning proper body positioning. If you are learning a sports discipline that requires specific body positioning training (like martial arts or dance) this is a good place in your workout to practice those positions as well.

Skill Work

- 5-10 minutes of handstand work, performed against the wall.

This is the only skill work that I recommend for untrained beginners unless you are specifically training for a sport or discipline that requires more. The time above includes rest times. You may only be inverted for five to ten seconds during the first few sets. With a minute or two of rest between sets, your total accumulation of handstand time may only end up being thirty to forty-five seconds. As you become stronger, this number may increase to sixty seconds or longer.

Handstand work is tough on the wrists, especially if you do not have much practice supporting your bodyweight on your wrists. Counteract this by performing additional mobility work, but if your wrists still feel weak, it is likely that handstand work may have to be decreased. You may end up only practicing handstands for thirty seconds each workout for your first few months of training until your wrists are conditioned enough to allow you to practice more. This is fine. Do not be worry if you have to take handstands or any other exercises slower if your wrists or any other joint(s) are limiting you. It is better to build up slowly and stay healthy than aggravate your joints and end up performing prehabilitation or rehabilitation work. In the long run, you will progress faster by starting slower.

Strength Work

- *Jumping Pull-ups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 50x0 tempo
- *Jumping Dips*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 50x0 tempo
- *Ring Rows*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Pushups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Squats (pistol progression or barbell)*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Deep Step-ups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Tuck L-Sit* for 60s total, in as many sets as needed, not to failure
- *Compression Work* for 3x10s

This is an example of a basic routine focused on improving strength in the categories of vertical pushing, horizontal pushing, vertical pulling, and horizontal pulling. This routine also facilitates balance between the muscles of the shoulder girdle and focuses on improving overall strength. You will notice several changes were made to the routine above from the example presented in Chapter 5. This is to better facilitate the needs of an untrained beginner. The changes made are as follows:

- All of the exercises were modified to the appropriate level. Here's how this may look in practice: You may begin with three repetitions of dips, five repetitions of pull-ups, eight repetitions of push-ups, and nine repetitions of rows and so forth for the remainder of the exercises. It is natural for there to be differences between the exercises; you will still increase them in subsequent workouts.
- An elongated 5s eccentric was added, useful to gain strength and improve overall for the jumping pull-ups and dips, which consist of a feet-assisted concentric.

The number of repetitions was increased from eight to fifteen across the board. Untrained beginners typically need to perform more repetitions to facilitate connective tissue strengthening before making bigger jumps in progressions. There is no detriment to higher repetitions and moving up in progressions for either hypertrophy or strength for untrained beginners. Hypertrophy remains the same because all fibers are capable of hypertrophy and need to be trained and beginners have inefficient neural pathways (lack of recruitment and synchronization), which means strength gains will come from multiple repetitions, not just working with lower repetitions.

The next section shows how all of this fits together in workouts and progressions from week to week and answers common questions.

Prehabilitation, Isolation Work, Flexibility Work, and Cool Down

- 3x1-minute sets of *Rice Bucket* (for the wrists)
- 3x10 *Biceps Curls*
- 3-5x30s *Splits Holds*
- 3-5x30s *German Hangs*
- 3-5x20s *Back Bridges*
- 1 minute of *Deep Breathing* (in through the nose, out through the mouth)

Finally, we have *prehabilitation*. As an untrained beginner, you can add or subtract the amount of work performed based on your needs. This is the time to do additional wrist work (aside from mobility) if you are having issues with your wrists from putting weight on them during handstands. Wall slides or shoulder stretching could be added if you cannot get your arms directly overhead for a handstand. You can do specific scapular work like retractions or depressions plus rotator cuff work to keep your shoulders healthy. Back and leg flexibility work may be needed. Yoga or Pilates may be good options if you need an extensive amount of mobility and/or flexibility in your lower body.

Most of the time, isolation work for weak links is not needed at this point, unless you want to add particular isolation work to increase strength and hypertrophy in specific muscles like your biceps. The most attention should be paid to the compound exercises in the routine in order to improve gross motor movement.

If you are an untrained beginner coming in with a high level of strength, you could consider integrating some basic static holds into your routine. Your workouts at this point will be focused on improving wall and freestanding handstands, L-sits, and possibly moving toward elbow levers (if that is one of your goals). Skill work used for other activities and disciplines may be integrated in here as well. As you move into Levels 3-4, the recommended exercises branch out into a varied set of movements and static positions as denoted by the exercises listed in the charts:

- Wall HeSPUs
- Back Lever
- Front Lever
- Planche
- Muscle-ups
- Rings Pushups
- Dips and L-Dips
- Pull-ups and L-Pull-ups
- Rows

Choose your direction based on both short-term and long-term goals. You may ultimately want to learn all of the skills listed above, but it is not a good idea to work toward all of them at once, as spreading yourself too thin will set you back. Instead, pick two pushing and two pulling goals and build a routine around them. It is best to select an overarching “theme” for your routine. Many people want to obtain the static holds as their primary goal. If that is your goal, build a routine around those strength isometrics. On the other hand, if your goal is to train for a sport, your routine should be more biased toward getting strong at movements and only adding static positions later as you improve in strength at many different ranges of motions. Remember, there are no right or wrong answers here; you need to decide what you want to learn and prioritize that.

Select these movements if you want to focus on isometric exercises:

- Wall HeSPUs
- Back Lever
- Front Lever
- Planche
- Muscle-ups
- Rows

Select these if want to focus on overall strength:

- Wall HeSPUs
- Muscle-ups
- Rings Pushups
- Dips and L-Dips
- Pull-ups and L-Pull-ups
- Rows

The warm-up, skill work, and prehabilitation/flexibility/cool down portions of your routine remain the same; the only difference is in the strength work portion. Here are two examples of what you could use for the strength work portion of your routine:

- *Jumping Pull-ups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 50x0 tempo
- *Jumping Dips*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 50x0 tempo
- *Ring Rows*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Pushups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Squats (pistol progression or barbell)*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo

- *Deep Step-ups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Tuck L-Sit* for 60s total, in as many sets as needed, not to failure
- *Compression Work* for 3x10s
- X seconds of *Frog Stand* or *SA Frog Stand* (planche)
- X seconds of *Tuck Back Lever* or *Advanced Tuck Back Lever*
- 3x5→15 of *Wall HeSPU* or *Muscle-up Work*
- X seconds of *Tuck Front Lever* or 3x5-12 of *Wide Rows Progression*
- *Squats (pistol progression or barbell)*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Deep Step-ups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Tuck L-Sit* for 60s total, in as many sets as needed, not to failure
- *Compression Work* for 3x10s

You should refer to the isometric charts to get how many Y sets of X second holds you need depending on your maximal holds. A purely dynamic-focused routine could look like this:

- *Dips and L-Dips* 3x(3→15) with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Pull-ups and L-Pull-ups* 3x(3→15) with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *RTO Pushups* 3x(3→15) with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Rows* 3x(3→15) with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Squats (pistol progression or barbell)*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Deep Step-ups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Tuck L-Sit* for 60s total, in as many sets as needed, not to failure
- *Compression Work* for 3x10s

Other exercises that may be substituted into your routine:

- Appropriate *Muscle-up or Assistance Work* 3x(3→15) with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Wall HeSPUs* 3x(3→15) with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo

At this level, you may not need to get to the point where you perform fifteen to twenty repetitions. If you have been working this many previously, it may be helpful to stop at twelve instead. However, if you are experiencing any connective tissue soreness or are at risk of a potential overuse injury, stick with the higher repetitions to train your connective tissue without overloading.

UNTRAINED BEGINNER: ROUTINE PROGRESSION

Your completed routine should look something like this:

Warm-Up

- *Blood Flow*: 10-20 Burpees, 60 Crawling (or variable distance, such as 100 meters)
- *Mobility*: 15x Wrist Circles, Shoulder Circles, Bodyweight Squats, and any other body part or joint that needs to be warmed up, 60 of Support Hold Work (parallel bars or rings or chairs/counters), 5x Skin the Cat / German Hangs
- *Positional Drills*: 30-60 of Plank, Both Side Planks, Reverse Plank, Hollow, and Arch Holds.

Skill Work

- 5-10 minutes of Handstand Work, performed against the wall.

Strength Work

- *Jumping Pull-ups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 50x0 tempo
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- *Ring Rows*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Pushups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
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- *Deep Step-ups*: 3x5→15 with 3 minutes of rest at 10x0 tempo
- *Tuck L-Sit* for 60s total, in as many sets as needed, not to failure
- *Compression Work* for 3x10s

Prehabilitation, Isolation Work, Flexibility Work, and Cool Down

- 3x1-minute sets of *Rice Bucket* (for the wrists)
- 3x10 *Biceps Curls*
- 3-5x30s *Splits Holds*
- 3-5x30s *German hangs*
- 3-5x20s *Back Bridges*
- 1 minute of *Deep Breathing* (in through the nose, out through the mouth)

Common Setbacks

There are certain areas where untrained beginners commonly run into difficulties.

Routine Balance: If you have poor posture, add an additional horizontal rowing motion in order to bring up the strength and muscle mass of the back. This will help balance things out, especially important if you have a desk job and your posture has been affected by prolonged sitting. There is also specific stretching to correct posture. Poor posture may not directly cause injuries, but if you improve your posture you will look better, feel better, have better proficiency in your technique, and increased ability to move through your range of motion without limitations or discomfort.

Adding an extra horizontal pulling exercise is helpful, since the most common poor posture involves the head and shoulders hunching forward. However, if you come from a background of pulling instead of pushing (such as swimming, rowing, or rock climbing), and your posture is imbalanced in the opposite direction, you may need to add an additional horizontal pushing exercise. Imbalances will become visible when performing exercises on the progression chart. If your pushing exercises are more than a progression or two ahead of pulling or if pulling is at a similar progression or above as pushing you may have an imbalance that should be corrected. Pushing tends to be a bit stronger than pulling.

Length of the Routine: It may take a beginner a decent amount of time to perform this routine, as there is so much that goes into a routine of this nature. The full-body routine is strongly recommended for this level, because it includes off days. A full-body routine can be shortened by moving any of the non-strength components to your rest days.

Your routine will include a quick warm-up, skill work, and strength work. Use your off days to perform additional mobility work, prehabilitation work, isolation work, and flexibility work. This is a great alternative for those who want to do something every day.

Tempo Modifications: If you are having trouble executing proper technique on the X portion (acceleration) of the 10x0 tempo, it may be effective to modify it to a 1010 tempo instead. Perfecting technique by practicing uniform movement is better than compromising form with a 10x0 tempo.

Strength Progression: Linear repetition progression (5-5-5 → 6-6-6 → 7-7-7) will typically be the best way to progress at this level. You can expect this to help you move through most of the beginner levels up to Level 5. However, it may be necessary to use repetition addition (5-5-5 → 6-5-5 → 6-6-5 → 6-6-6) or some of the other method of progression if you get stuck after a workout or two. In particular, you may be progressing effectively with one exercise like pushups, but get stuck on dips. If this is the case, continue to progress with the linear repetition progression with pushups and change the progression with the dips. Here's an example of what this could look like:

- *Pushups:* 5-5-5 → 6-6-6 → 7-7-7 → 8-8-8
- *Dips:* 5-5-5 → 6-5-5 → 6-6-5 → 6-6-6

This is completely normal and may even occur with exercises that involve the same muscle group. There could be multiple factors at play. Some exercises progress faster than others. Fatigue from performing pushups could slow your progression with dips. The key at this stage is not to get hung up on the lack of progress you are making (whether real or perceived) as long as you are making progress.

Some people stall on pushups while others do not stall until they reach one-arm pushups or high-level planche work. Every individual is different. What works for another person may not work for you. There are no “one size fits all” rules in bodyweight training. This is why it is so important to learn how your own body works in relation to training. Don't push yourself trying to keep up with someone else's progress.

Paralysis by Analysis: Most people who are new to exercise are eager to find the perfect routine. Let's disabuse you of that notion right now. *There is no perfect routine.* In fact, as the saying goes: “The best routine is the one you are actually doing.” Some people spend weeks thinking about how to construct the perfect routine, perhaps even contacting seasoned athletes and coaches for advice, while others dive straight into training. The person who does the latter will be that many weeks ahead in their training. Their routine may be imperfect, but it is actually being performed. *Get moving now and make adjustments as you go.* Part of learning how to properly construct a solid routine is figuring out how your body responds to different exercises, and you cannot learn this from the advice of others. Once your routine is off the ground, that is the time to potentially begin seeking advice on how you can modify it later.

Routine Mania: On the other end of the spectrum are the athletes who have a tendency to construct a routine, try it out, and immediately abandon it. These people pop up on forums talking about their new routines and asking for critiques. A few weeks later, they have a different “new routine.” This is extremely counterproductive, as both strength and hypertrophy are predicated on progressive overload, which assumes you are performing the same exercises over and over and actually progressing with them. You will make better progress sticking with your original routine than you will by switching to a “new and improved” routine after only two weeks. In the beginning, the minimum a routine should last is four weeks because you will naturally

see progress if you stick with exercises for that period of time. Mesocycles should last about four to eight weeks. Untrained beginners may see some progress in as little as two or three workouts, but it typically takes three to four weeks to see significant progress in terms of physique or strength. Sticking to the program you created is important because it will teach you about yourself and how your body responds to exercise in the latter weeks of the program.

Overuse Modifications: Untrained beginners are likely to have to substantially modify their routines based on what issues appear. One common issue is discovering that too fast progression is too difficult on your connective tissues. In this case, increasing the repetitions from fifteen to twenty may be useful. Additionally, integrating more prehabilitation and mobility work is should be readily considered for untrained beginners.

It is impossible to recommend set amounts of prehabilitation, mobility, and flexibility work because everyone is different. You must learn the underlying concepts for implementing this type of work into your routine. For example, if you feel your wrists are being overworked, follow this two-step process:

- Eliminate, reduce volume, or substitute exercises.
- Add additional prehabilitation, isolation, mobility, or flexibility work as needed for the particular area.

Eliminating, reducing volume, or substituting exercises is fairly straightforward. If your wrists are being aggravated while performing handstands, eliminate handstands until your wrists are better prepared to handle them. In the meantime, work on other wrist-supported exercises like supports or planks that will condition your wrists without aggravating them. Add additional prehabilitation, isolation, mobility, or flexibility work for the particular area as needed. Some of the extensive wrist exercises mentioned earlier in this chapter may be particularly useful. You can add in some dumbbell wrist curls or rice bucket exercises. If you feel unsure, or this is all too complicated, you can always ask a medical professional, such as an orthopedic sports doctor or physical therapist. You can also consult coaches, athletes who are more advanced than yourself, or even people with more extensive experience than you on the Internet. I recommend these Reddit threads: www.reddit.com/r/bodyweightfitness and www.reddit.com/r/overcominggravity.

Avoiding Injuries: In the long run, learning how to modify your routine based on how your body responds—especially in the context of potential overuse injuries—is going to be THE most important thing you can learn when it comes to training. The number one predictor of an injury is a previous injury. Knowing when you need to back down and modify your routine is valuable information that will stick with you for decades in both coaching and training.